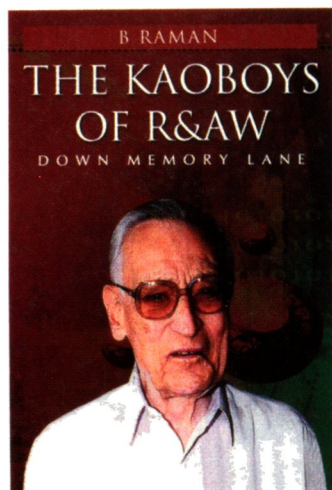
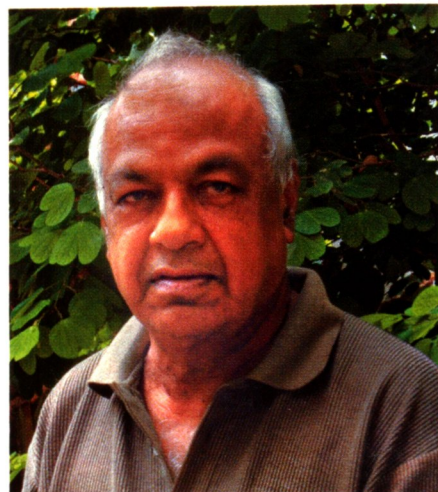




RAW TRUTHS

A startling glimpse into the working of India's external intelligence agency



THE UNSEEN HAND: Kao

LOYAL SPY: The author

In the foyer of the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) headquarters in Delhi stands a life-size statue of a cowboy with a likeness to founder Rameshwar Nath Kao. The statue was based on a smaller image presented to Kao in the mid-1970s by the father of another cowboy, George W. Bush, while he served as CIA chief. Yet, Kao, who built R&AW into a professional intelligence organisation in just three years, was anything but a cowboy. A behind-the-scenes operator who gave credit to his colleagues when things went well and took the rap when things failed, Kao's unseen hand was seen in the events like the creation of Bangladesh, India's role in the Great Game in Afghanistan, and in Sikkim, Nagaland and Mizoram, when he worked as Indira Gandhi's chief spy and later as adviser to Rajiv Gandhi. This was the stuff thrillers are made of. Yet you wouldn't hear of it from the Kaoboy—the men handpicked to staff the intelligence agency in 1968—who, like their reclusive mentor, prefer to carry their secrets to the grave. Bahukutumbi Raman, a 1961 batch IPS officer, breaks this omerta. Raman, who re-

tired as additional secretary in charge of counter-terrorism in R&AW in 1994, records his secret service years with brief insights into the personality of Kao. The agency had its share of successes and failures—it pulled off the liberation of Bangladesh, but failed to prevent the assassination of Indira and Rajiv Gandhi. It functioned as a quasi-foreign service through the Cold War and learned how the business of intelligence was a dirty one—the agencies of France and the US repeatedly penetrated R&AW even when they enjoyed excellent relations with India. *The Kaoboy of R&AW: Down Memory Lane* (Lancer, 300pp, Rs 795) reveals bizarre aspects of cooperation—the CIA trained officers of the ISI in the use of terrorism, while also training R&AW in techniques of countering terrorism. Kao's observations hold true even today: "One should never trust the US in matters concerning Pakistan. The US will never act against Pakistan for anything it does to India." Despite the revelations, Raman gives you the feeling he is hiding more than he is telling, and still remains a Kaoboy.

by Sandeep Unnithan

EXCERPTS

THE MOLE IN YAHYA KHAN'S OFFICE

Sankaran Nair (the second chief of R&AW) was the leading expert of the intelligence community on Pakistan and the rest of the Islamic world. He was dealing with Pakistan even in the IB before the R&AW was formed. He had built up a network of sources in Pakistan at various levels—particularly in the armed forces. A mole of his in the office of General Yahya Khan reported in the last week of November 1971, that the Pakistan Air Force (PAF) intended making a pre-emptive strike on the forward air bases of the Indian Air Force (IAF) in the

western sector on December 1. The IAF was immediately alerted by Nair and Indira Gandhi was informed by Kao. The IAF ordered a high alert and took necessary precautionary measures to thwart the planned pre-emptive strike. Nothing happened on December 1 and 2. On the morning of December 3, the IAF headquarters told Nair that they could not continue to keep their pilots in a state of high alert any longer. He requested them to continue it for another 24 hours and downgrade it on the morning of December 4, if nothing happened. He assured the

BETRAYED: Yahya Khan



IAF headquarters that his source was very reliable and generally accurate in his intelligence. The IAF headquarters agreed to continue the high alert. On the evening of December 3, the PAF launched a pre-emptive strike, which was a total failure because the IAF had advance warning of it. Nair checked up as to how, his source, who was generally accurate, gave the date of the planned strike as December 1. It was found that in his coded message the source had given the date correctly as December 3, but the decoders in the R&AW headquarters had incorrectly decoded it as December 1.